seven wickets. We had batted well in our first and only innings, making 544, and Rahul and I scored centuries, setting the match up for Zaheer.

South Africa in India, February 2010

We reassembled to take on the South Africans in the first of two Tests at Nagpur on 6 February. The points situation meant that whoever won the series would be the number-one Test team.

In the first Test, Dale Steyn bowled brilliantly, ending up with ten wickets, and we were comprehensively beaten. Hashim Amla, with 253, and Jacques Kallis, with 173, batted superbly for South Africa and Amla was in extraordinary batting form right through the series. Kallis has always been a champion performer and is undoubtedly the best all-round cricketer of our generation. It has been a pleasure competing with players like these, who will surely be remembered as all-time greats.

Though we lost the game, I did manage to make a hundred in the second innings and I liked to think that my plan against Dale Steyn had started to work. He is an exceptional fast bowler and we knew we would need to play him well to make a comeback in the second Test, so the second-innings batting effort gave us a little hope in this regard. On the other hand, we had to accept that we had made it difficult for ourselves and were going to have to play out of our skins to retain our number-one Test ranking.

We were surprised to see a green top awaiting us at Eden Gardens. It had all but nullified the concept of home advantage, but there was nothing we could do about the pitch at that stage.

Again South Africa started well, but then we staged a miraculous comeback towards the end of the first day. From a position of strength at 218–1, South Africa collapsed to a modest 296 all out thanks to some terrific bowling from Zaheer and Harbhajan. We sensed we were in with a chance and put together a big first-innings total, with as many as four of us – Sehwag, Laxman, Dhoni and myself – getting hundreds. Sehwag and I had a terrific partnership of 249 after losing two quick wickets and we also scored at a phenomenal pace, unsettling the South Africans. Anything on middle-and-leg was flicked to the on side, while anything outside off stump was cut or driven. It was a dominant partnership and swung the pendulum in our favour.